Moral Injury Among Professionals in K-12 Education

A Mixed Methods Inquiry

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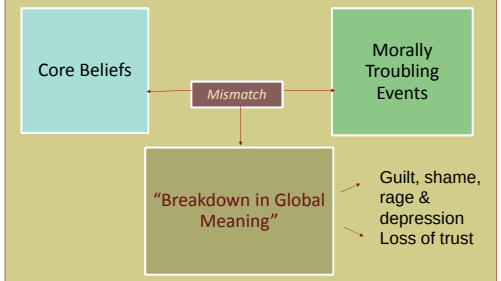
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Introduction

Moral Injury = The lasting psychological, spiritual, social, and existential harm that results when one perpetrates or witnesses actions that violate deeply held moral beliefs and expectations.



Why study moral injury in the context of U.S. K-12 education?

- Education is a morally high-stakes context
- Exposure to morally injurious events can lead to emotional distress and potentially harmful behavioral outcomes
- The presence of moral injury signifies the presence of moral transgressions

Research Questions

- **Q1:** To what extent do K-12 public educators experience morally injurious events in their workplace?
- **Q2:** What individual or school-level characteristics are associated with a K-12 public educator experiencing morally injurious events?
- **Q3:** How might the phenomenon of "moral injury," as experienced by educators, take shape in the context of K-12 public education?

Methods

Research Design

Explanatory Sequential Mixed Methods

Quantitative Sample

- N = 223

22.4% Male
77.1% Female
0.4% None Listed

77.6% White
4% African American
2.7% Asian American
2.2% Latinx
0.4% Native American
11.2% Multi-racial
1.8% No race listed

Mean Yrs in Education = 14.9
(1-44 years)

55% Classroom Teachers
24% SpEd/ELL
10% Mental Health
11% Instructional Support

120 Elementary
103 Non-Elementary

60.6% @ schools with >75% F/R lunch

60.1% @ schools with < 30% White students

Quantitative Measures

- **Moral Injury Events Scale – modified (MIES)**
- Trauma-Related Guilt Inventory (TRGI)
- Stress of Conscience Questionnaire (SCQ)
- Copenhagen Burnout Inventory (CBI)
- Intention to Leave Scale (ILS)
- Demographics

Qualitative Sample

N= 21

2 Men
19 Women

15 White
1 African American
2 Asian American
1 Native American
2 Multi-racial

Mean Years in Education = 19.6
(3-35 years)

10 Classroom Teachers
5 SpEd/ELL
5 Mental Health
1 Instructional Support

11 Elementary
10 Non-Elementary

20 @ schools with > 80% FRL
1 school = 68% FRL
(68% - 96%)

17 @schools with < 10% White students
4 @ schools with < 25% White Students

Qualitative Measure

- 60-90 minute semi-structured interview

Quantitative Results

MIES Scores

	K-12 Professionals (n=218)	CPS Professionals (Haight et al., 2017) (n = 38)	Air Force Psychiatric Outpatients (Bryan et al., 2016) (n = 151)	Army National Guard (Bryan et al., 2016) (n = 935)
Transgress -Other	4.4 (1.5)	5.1 (1.0)	3.7 (1.7)	4.3 (1.7)
Transgress -Self	2.9 (1.5)	2.7 (1.4)	2.5 (1.7)	2.7 (1.4)
Betrayal	3.8 (1.5)	3.1 (1.2)	3.2 (1.7)	3.1 (1.2)

Regression Analysis: MIES– Transgressions-Others

Variable	B	SE B	β	t	p
Gender	.361	.214	.106	1.684	.094
Mental_Health	1.001	.318	.198	3.152	.002
%Students_of_ Color	2.264	.436	.326	5.190	.000
	Adjusted $R^2 = .153$				

Regression Analysis: MIES– Transgressions-Self

Variable	B	SE B	β	t	p
%Students_of_ Color	2.138	.438	.317	4.883	.000
	Adjusted $R^2 = .096$				

Regression Analysis: MIES– Betrayal

Variable	B	SE B	β	t	p
Gender	.446	.218	.136	2.047	.042
%Students_of_ Color	1.258	.451	.186	2.789	.006
	Adjusted $R^2 = .047$				

Qualitative Results

- The Trauma of Racism & Poverty
- "Colonizing the Natives"
- "Restorative Justice" as a Buzzword, not a Practice
- "Just Don't Look Under the Hood"
- The Fine Line Between Empathy & Pity

Discussion

- Moral injury is a relevant concept for K-12 professionals
- Most significant predictor of moral injury was the percent of students of color in a school
- Percent of students of color was highly correlated with the percent of students receiving free or reduced lunch (r = .963)
- Quantitative and qualitative data support the idea of the importance of "contextual injustices" (Levinson, 2015) in moral injury
- Qualitative data illustrate what McDonald (2017) refers to as the sense of "global loss" that is at the core of moral injury
- **Moral injury among K-12 professionals indicates the presence of moral transgressions in our public schools. To address moral injury in K-12 education, we must work to identify and remedy the sources of moral transgressions.**